

LIFE IN THE LAND OF opportunity

COLONIAL AMERICA

The arrival of European settlers in North America changed the fortunes of the entire continent forever. In the late 15th and early 16th centuries, Europeans began to colonize the so-called “New World,” sparing little thought for the people who already inhabited the Americas. Settlers went to America for a number of reasons—from the promise of land and money to the opportunity to be free from religious persecution. For European women, too, the building of the colonies allowed them a chance to be part of a new society, and to leave the old behind for what they perceived to be greener pastures.

Many Europeans were struck by the different roles that Native American women played in their societies (see pp. 98–99), compared to their own cultural norms. Among Eastern Woodland Indians in North America, who were among the first that British settlers encountered, women had defined gender roles and were in charge of rearing children and farming, while men hunted, fished, and conducted politics and



◀ Chief's bride

In native cultures, women played a more prominent role in society compared to their Western counterparts. In this 1591 engraving, a chief's new bride is carried to him in a ceremonial procession.

